

know, no such dependence has been demonstrated, and to the extent that I have analyzed the evidence, it cannot be demonstrated.

The Importance of Objective Evidence

Even when MSS are collated by persons with a negative bias (bias against the MSS), if they will record the collation accurately, the result is valuable. The continuous text MSS are the primary witnesses to the NT Text. To be able to trace the transmissional history of individual readings, we need complete collations of a large number of extant MSS, the more the better. I wish to illustrate what I have affirmed with the *Editio Critica Maior* (ECM) collations for James and 1 John. They were done while Kurt Aland was still directing the Institute for New Testament Textual Research in Münster (INTF), and the work reflects his bias against the Byzantine MSS. (By the time the ECM for the General Epistles was published, 1997, Kurt had died, but since his wife, Barbara, succeeded him as director of the Institute, INTF, there would be no change in the theoretical orientation.)¹

As of May, 1988, Kurt and Barbara Aland had excluded “more than 1,175 minuscules” (p. 138) as exhibiting “a purely or predominately Byzantine text”. They go on to say, “they are all irrelevant for textual criticism, at least for establishing the original form of the text and its development in the early centuries” (p. 142). (*The Text of the New Testament*, Eerdmans, 1989.) That this bias prevailed in the *Editio Critica Maior* for James is quite clear. Without apology the editors excluded some 340 of the 522 MSS they evaluated because they “attest the Majority text in at least 90% of the test passages” (p. 12). The “test passages” refers to the 98 variant sets taken from the seven General Epistles presented in *Text und Textwert*. However, they did include GA 18 and 35 to represent Soden’s K^x (my Family 35), and GA 1, 424, 607, 617 and 2423 to represent the core Byzantine MSS that were excluded. Apart from those seven, they class another 70 (of the included MSS) as being Byzantine, albeit falling below the 90% threshold.

So why do I say that their work is valuable, in spite of their bias? I hasten to explain. In the critical apparatus of my *The Greek New Testament According to Family 35*, I list eight f³⁵ readings (for James) as having 30% overall attestation, or less, which would make them more or less diagnostic

¹ Indeed, for James the editors included 70 MSS that they classed as Byzantine; but for 1 Peter they reduced the number to 51, and for 2 Peter to 44. For 1 John it was reduced to 41—one might conclude that Barbara was even more radical than Kurt in her disdain for the Byzantine MSS.